

Passive OSINT Investigation

Target: NIIT Port Harcourt (NIIT PH)

Passive reconnaissance report — publicly available information only

1. Scope & Rules of Engagement

This report documents a passive Open Source Intelligence (OSINT) investigation conducted against the publicly available digital footprint of NIIT Port Harcourt (NIIT PH), an IT training center. The objective was to demonstrate reconnaissance methodology as used in the early stages of a penetration test or security assessment.

Ground rules followed

- Investigation limited strictly to passive, publicly available information.
- No active scanning, exploitation, login attempts, or unauthorized access of any kind.
- No contact was made with any individuals identified during the investigation.
- Purpose is educational.

All findings below come from public records: WHOIS databases, certificate transparency logs, public DNS resolvers, Shodan, LinkedIn, and Have I Been Pwned.

2. Methodology

The investigation followed a structured passive reconnaissance approach, broken into three phases:

- Phase 1 — Domain & Infrastructure: WHOIS, subdomain enumeration, DNS records, IP/hosting analysis
- Phase 2 — People: identifying publicly listed personnel and organizational structure via LinkedIn
- Phase 3 — Digital Footprint: breach exposure checks on public-facing email addresses

3. Phase 1 — Domain & Infrastructure

3.1 WHOIS Lookup

A WHOIS query was run against the primary domain, niitph.com, via whois.com.

whois.com/whois/niitph.com

Click to go back, hold to see history

Whois Identity for everyone

Domains Hosting Websites Email Security Whois Deals

niitph.com [Make offer](#)

Updated 1 second ago

Domain Information

Domain:	niitph.com
Registered On:	2025-05-19
Expires On:	2027-05-19
Updated On:	2026-07-19
Status:	client transfer prohibited
Name Servers:	amit.ns.cloudflare.com indie.ns.cloudflare.com

Registrar Information

Registrar:	Dynadot Inc
IANA ID:	472

Figure 1 — WHOIS record for niitph.com

- Domain registered: 19 May 2025 — a relatively recent registration.
- Expires: 19 May 2027. Last updated: 19 July 2026.
- Status: client transfer prohibited (standard registrar-level protection against unauthorized transfer).
- Name servers: amit.ns.cloudflare.com / indie.ns.cloudflare.com — confirms the domain sits behind Cloudflare.
- Registrar: Dynadot Inc.

Assessment: the recent registration date suggests either a new domain, a rebrand, or a migration to a new platform. This was kept in mind as a hypothesis while gathering further evidence, rather than treated as confirmed.

3.2 Subdomain Enumeration

Certificate transparency data was queried via Merklemap (a crt.sh alternative, used because crt.sh was unavailable at the time).

The screenshot shows the Merklemap web interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with links: ZeroFS: Merklemap's Storage Engine, Pricing, Dns Database, Documentation, Sign in, and a Sign up button. Below the navigation bar is a search bar containing 'niitph.com' and a Search button. Below the search bar, it says 'Total ~23 subdomains'. To the right of this, there's a 'Highlight matches' toggle switch which is turned on, and an 'Export all to .csv' button. Below this is a promotional banner for Merklemap's subscription service. The main content is a table with three columns: HOSTNAME, COMMON NAME, and FIRST SEEN. The table lists several subdomains: login.niitph.com, staging.niitph.com, portal.niitph.com, app.niitph.com, api.niitph.com, and dev.niitph.com. The first-seen dates for all these subdomains are clustered around late June 2026. Below the table, there's a message '3 more results available' and a 'Create Account' button.

HOSTNAME	COMMON NAME	FIRST SEEN
login.niitph.com	login.niitph.com	6/30/2026
staging.niitph.com	staging.niitph.com	6/29/2026
portal.niitph.com	portal.niitph.com	6/29/2026
app.niitph.com	app.niitph.com	6/29/2026
api.niitph.com	api.niitph.com	6/29/2026
dev.niitph.com	dev.niitph.com	6/29/2026

Figure 2 — Subdomains discovered via certificate transparency logs

- Approximately 23 subdomains identified in total.
- Notable subdomains: login.niitph.com, staging.niitph.com, portal.niitph.com, app.niitph.com, api.niitph.com, dev.niitph.com.
- First-seen dates cluster around late June 2026, consistent with active recent development.

Assessment: the presence of login, portal, app and api subdomains confirms NIIT PH operates a real web application/platform beyond a static marketing site — meaningfully expanding the attack surface beyond the homepage. The staging and dev subdomains are the most security-relevant finding of this phase: non-production environments are frequently less hardened than production and, if left publicly accessible, can expose debug information, default credentials, or outdated software. This is flagged as a risk item in Section 6.

3.3 DNS Records

A, MX, and TXT records were queried for niitph.com using dnschecker.org, cross-checked against multiple public resolvers (Google, Quad9, OpenDNS, NextDNS).

← → ↻ 🌐 dnschecker.org/#A/niitph.com



Home DNS Lookup All Tools Public DNS List

CHECK DNS

A Search

   CD Flag ☐ Refresh: sec.

 Mountain View CA, United States Google 	104.21.40.29 172.67.174.222	
 Berkeley, US Quad9 	172.67.174.222 104.21.40.29	
 San Francisco CA, United States OpenDNS 	172.67.174.222 104.21.40.29	
 Wilmington, United States of America NextDNS Inc 	104.21.40.29 172.67.174.222	

Figure 3 — A record for niitph.com

- A record resolves to 104.21.40.29 and 172.67.174.222, consistent across all resolvers checked.
- Both IPs fall within Cloudflare's published IP ranges — the domain is proxied, and the true origin server IP is not exposed through standard DNS resolution.

CHECK DNS

MX

Search

   CD Flag

☐ Refresh: 20 sec.

 Mountain View CA, United States	-	×
Google 		
 Berkeley, US	-	×
Quad9 		
 San Francisco CA, United States	-	×
OpenDNS 		
 Wilmington, United States of America	-	×
NextDNS Inc. 		
 San Francisco, US	-	×
Quad9 		

Figure 4 — MX record query returning no results

- No MX records were found for the apex domain — meaning email is not configured to be received directly on niitph.com. Mail may be handled via a subdomain, a different domain entirely, or may simply not be provisioned yet given how recently the domain was registered.

CHECK DNS

TXT

▼

Search

+

✓

CD Flag

Refresh:

20

sec.

Mountain View CA, United States Google	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1 OkE-4TiqLQ8I5ZFQ	✓
Berkeley, US Quad9	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1 OkE-4TiqLQ8I5ZFQ	✓
San Francisco CA, United States OpenDNS	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1 OkE-4TiqLQ8I5ZFQ	✓
Wilmington, United States of America NextDNS Inc.	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1 OkE-4TiqLQ8I5ZFQ	✓
San Francisco, US Quad9	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1 OkE-4TiqLQ8I5ZFQ	✓
Alpharetta, United States ZCORUM	google-site-verification=3OJHxZWD N_P_v2hHDaDke47_Jp1	✓

Figure 5 — TXT record for niitph.com

- A single TXT record was found: a Google Search Console site-verification string, confirming the organization actively manages the domain through Google's webmaster tools.
- No SPF record was found. Combined with the absence of MX records, this confirms no active email infrastructure on the apex domain at the time of testing. This is noted as a forward-looking risk: should mail ever be enabled on this domain without an SPF record, it would be vulnerable to sender spoofing.

3.4 Origin Server / Shodan Analysis

A Shodan lookup was performed against the resolved Cloudflare IP (172.67.174.222) to check for any exposed services or banner information.

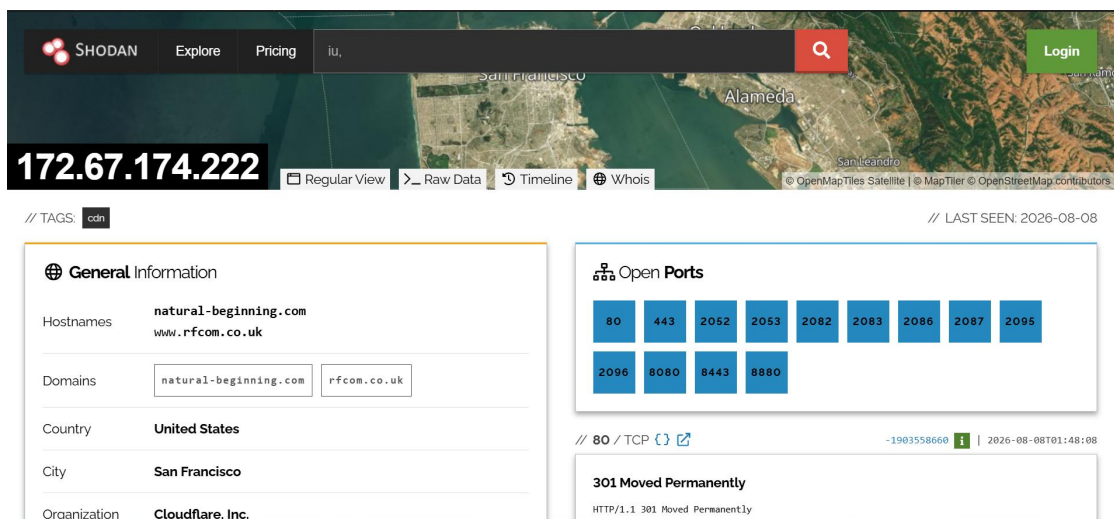


Figure 6 — Shodan record for 172.67.174.222

- Shodan confirms the IP belongs to Cloudflare, Inc., tagged as CDN infrastructure.
- Hostnames returned (natural-beginning.com, www.rfcom.co.uk) belong to unrelated organizations sharing the same Cloudflare edge node — not evidence of any relationship to NIIT PH.
- Open ports shown (80, 443, 2052, 2082, 8080, 8443, etc.) are Cloudflare's standard proxy ports, not NIIT PH's actual server configuration.

Assessment: NIIT PH's true hosting infrastructure is fully masked behind Cloudflare's reverse proxy and is not discoverable through direct internet-wide scanning tools such as Shodan. This reflects reasonable baseline security hygiene on the infrastructure side.

3.5 Independent DNS Resolution Check

DNS resolution was independently verified from a local vantage point to cross-check the earlier public-resolver findings.

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.26200.8875]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\user>nslookup niitph.com
Server: Unknown
Address: 192.168.2.189

Non-authoritative answer:
Name: niitph.com
Addresses: 2606:4700:3030::6815:281d
          2606:4700:3034::ac43:aede
          104.21.40.29
          172.67.174.222

C:\Users\user>
```


Figure 7 — nslookup query from local Windows Command Prompt

This query, run locally, returned results consistent with the earlier public DNS lookups: the same two Cloudflare IPv4 addresses, plus two Cloudflare IPv6 addresses.

- The local result matches the public DNS findings exactly, reinforcing that niitph.com resolves consistently to Cloudflare's proxy infrastructure across independent vantage points.

4. Phase 2 — People & Organizational Structure

A LinkedIn search for "NIIT Port Harcourt Centre" was conducted to identify publicly listed personnel and infer organizational structure. Only publicly visible profile information was reviewed; no connection requests or messages were sent.

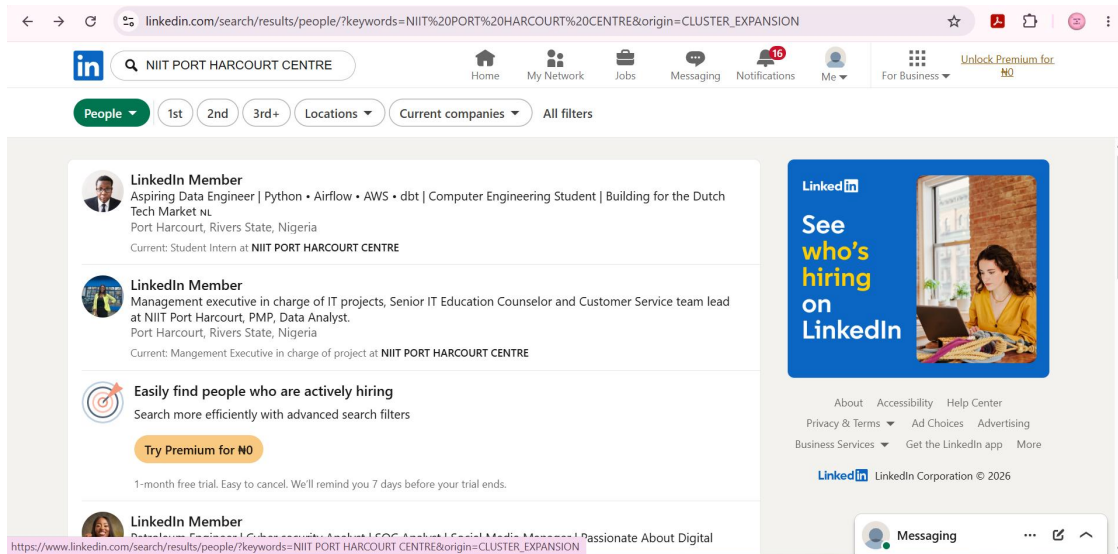


Figure 8 — LinkedIn search results for NIIT Port Harcourt Centre

- A Student Intern role was identified, self-described as an aspiring Data Engineer (Python, Airflow, AWS, dbt).
- A Management Executive role was identified, described as overseeing IT projects, acting as Senior IT Education Counselor, and Customer Service team lead — holding a PMP certification and data analyst skills.
- Additional profiles appeared in the results (including a Cybersecurity/SOC Analyst background) but were not fully catalogued.
- No standalone LinkedIn company page could be located for NIIT Port Harcourt specifically, suggesting it may operate as a branch/franchise under the broader NIIT brand rather than maintaining independent social presence.

Assessment: the roles identified confirm NIIT PH functions as an IT training center, consistent with the subdomain findings (login/portal/app suggest a student- or staff-facing platform). The individual in the IT management role is the most security-relevant personnel finding, as they likely hold elevated access to the platform infrastructure identified in Phase 1. This kind of role-mapping is a standard early step in social-engineering or spear-phishing risk assessment, though no such action was taken here.

5. Phase 3 — Digital Footprint & Breach Exposure

A breach-exposure check was run against a common generic address for the domain using Have I Been Pwned.

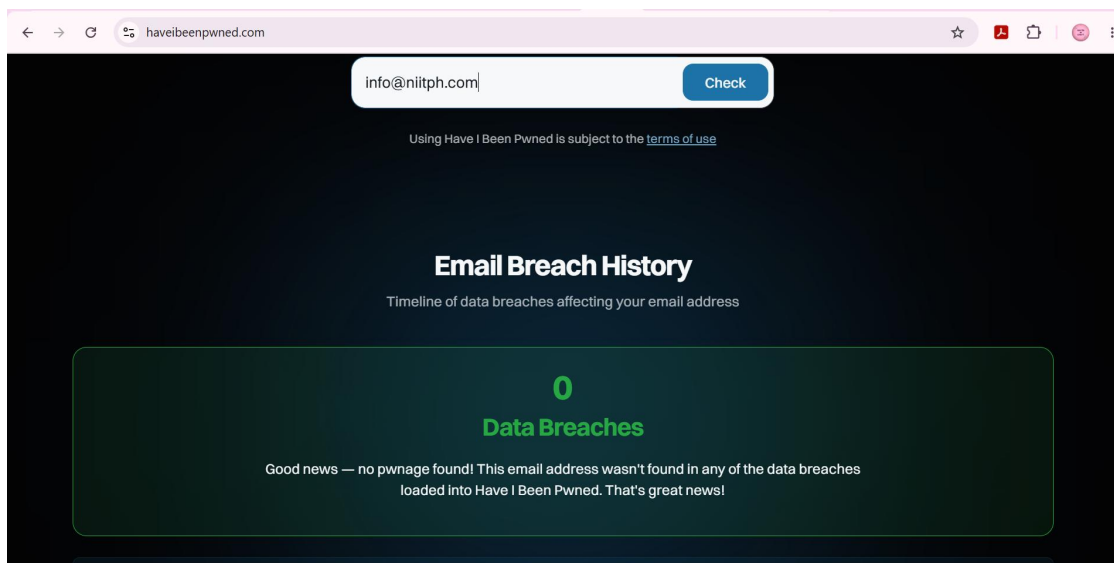


Figure 9 — Have I Been Pwned result for info@niitph.com

- info@niitph.com returned zero breach matches.

Assessment: no exposure was found, which is expected given the domain's recent registration (May 2025) — it has had limited time to appear in breach datasets. This does not rule out exposure for other address formats (e.g. personal name-based addresses) that were not tested as part of this investigation.

5.1 Google Dorking — Recommended Follow-Up Queries

The following dork queries are standard follow-up steps for this type of investigation. They were not executed as part of this engagement's scope but are documented here as recommended next steps, along with the risk level of what each could plausibly surface if run:

Command	Purpose	Potential Finding	Risk Level
site:niitph.com	Domain reconnaissance	All indexed pages and subdomains	Low
site:niitph.com filetype:pdf	Document harvesting	Internal memos, forms, staff lists	Moderate
site:niitph.com inurl:admin	Panel discovery	Links to administrative portals	High
site:niitph.com filetype:xlsx	Data leak hunting	Spreadsheets with student/staff data	Critical
site:niitph.com intitle:"index of"	Directory traversal	Unprotected folders exposing raw files	Critical

6. Intelligence Correlation & Threat Analysis

This section illustrates how a threat actor could chain the findings above into a functional attack path, purely as an analytical exercise — no such actions were taken.

- Phase 1 — Footprint Identification: an attacker maps the domain (niitph.com) and its DNS/registration history, identifying it as a recently launched, actively developed platform.

- Phase 2 — Subdomain & Surface Mapping: certificate transparency data reveals ~23 subdomains, including login, portal, app, api, and — critically — the non-production staging and dev environments, which are typically less hardened.
- Phase 3 — Infrastructure Assessment: DNS and Shodan analysis confirm the origin server is masked behind Cloudflare, ruling out direct IP-based exploitation and forcing an attacker toward application-layer or identity-based approaches instead.
- Phase 4 — Identity Correlation: LinkedIn reconnaissance identifies personnel and roles, including an IT management contact with likely elevated access — a natural target for phishing or social-engineering attempts aimed at the login/portal systems identified in Phase 2.

7. Findings & Risk Summary

7.1 Intelligence Findings Summary

Component	Finding	Strategic Relevance
Domain	Registered May 2025, Cloudflare-fronted	New/actively developed platform
Subdomains	~23 found, incl. staging & dev	Non-production exposure risk
Email infra	No MX or SPF on apex domain	No spoofing risk yet; flag if added later
Origin server	Masked behind Cloudflare	Not exploitable via direct IP scanning
Personnel	IT management role identified	Social-engineering target
Breach exposure	None found (info@ address)	Low current exposure

7.2 Risk Rating

Risk Domain	Rating	Recommended Action
Non-production exposure (staging/dev)	High	Restrict access via auth wall, VPN, or IP allow-list
Origin server exposure	Low	Cloudflare fronting is effective; maintain current setup
Email spoofing potential	Low (currently)	Configure SPF/DMARC before enabling mail on apex domain
Human attack surface	Moderate	Security awareness training for administrative/IT staff
Breach exposure	Low	No action needed at this time; recheck periodically

Overall assessment: infrastructure-level hygiene is reasonable (Cloudflare fronting, no exposed origin, no current email spoofing risk), but the exposed non-production subdomains and identifiable IT personnel together form the most realistic path a motivated attacker would pursue — combining a technical foothold attempt on staging/dev with a social-engineering attempt against identified staff.

8. Conclusion

This investigation demonstrates a structured, passive OSINT methodology across infrastructure, personnel, and breach-exposure analysis, using only publicly available tools and data sources. No active scanning or exploitation was performed at any stage. The findings illustrate how a meaningful picture of an organization's external attack surface and personnel structure can be built entirely from open sources — the same first step an attacker (or a defender performing an external assessment) would take before any active engagement.